day, voters were reportedly running around looking for their names on the voters' list at their old booths, only to find them struck off with no one in the party the wiser on where their names had gone. The BJP still won Bhopal and Indore by strong margins, but not before some stress owing to the low polling and mismanagement. It lost the Katni mayoral contest to a party rebel who had been denied the ticket. Katni is part of Khajuraho LS seat, represented by BJP state chief V.D. Sharma.

The municipal elections also marked the entry of parties other than the BJP and the Congress. AAP bagged the Singrauli municipal corporation, with Rani Agarwal winning the mayor's seat in a triangular contest. Delhi CM Arvind Kejriwal had held a roadshow in Singrauli, an indicator that AAP felt it was within striking distance. The Congress's narrow defeat at Burhanpur, by a mere 600 votes, came amid allegations that Asaduddin Owaisi's AIMIM ensured the BJP's victory as its "B team". The AIMIM polled over 10,000 votes here and almost 10,000 in neighbouring Khandwa—both towns border Maharashtra where it has a presence. The AIMIM won four councillor seats in Jabalpur, Khandwa and Burhanpur.

While the AIMIM's presence in MP may be heartening for the BJP,

THE BJP'S FAMED POLL MACHINERY AND BOOTH-LEVEL STRATEGIES WENT MISSING IN THE MUNICIPAL POLL

assuming that it eats into Congress votes, AAP's presence may not have the same effect—it is likely to impact both the BJP and Congress, but more so the ruling party. Besides winning Singrauli, the AAP candidate in Gwalior polled 45,762 votes, while five corporators were elected in Singrauli and 11 councillors in 10 tier-three nagar parishads.

With its improved tally, should the Congress think all is well? "Elections are won with good candidates and party support," says political analyst Girija Shankar. "The Congress won in seats where it had better candidates and leaders backing them. For success in 2023, the Congress will have to get the latter right." Both the BJP and the Congress celebrated after the results, with PM Narendra Modi and Congress general secretary Priyanka Gandhi equally congratulating party workers for a "victory". That itself speaks of how open it was. ■

ANI



ALSO IN THE RUNNING
Congress leader D.K. Shivakumar at a protest rally in Bengaluru

what's perceived as a bid for oneupmanship.

Siddaramaiah has pointed out that he has seldom celebrated his birthday, so as to deny any role in drawing up the plan. In fact, for a long time he had put down August 12, 1948, as his date of birth, till he happened to visit his old school where records showed it was August 3, 1947, he told an interviewer.

Meanwhile, Shivakumar took the sagacious position that supporters couldn't be stopped from holding commemorative events for their leaders although, personally, he always discouraged his followers from organising such events. On his sixtieth birthday on May 15 this year, Shivakumar travelled to Kedarnath. But his brother D.K. Suresh put things across more directly at a recent meeting to discuss the upcoming event—a Lok Sabha member from Bengaluru Rural, Suresh's concern was that it shouldn't adversely impact the party in an election year.

In the Karnataka Congress, Siddaramaiah and Shivakumar are the two foremost leaders—one a former chief minister, and the other the state party chief. Both are seen to be positioning themselves as the face of the party, and as its chief ministerial candidate, given that Karnataka is heading to polls in about